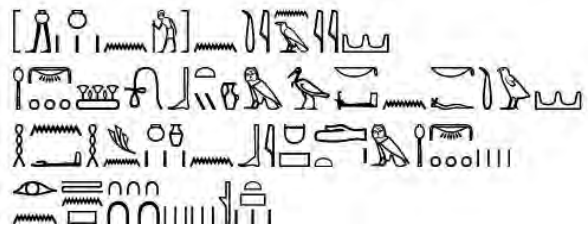
tj-nꜣ-y AND *kft(j)w* IN THE ANNALS OF THUTMOSE III: A REASSESSMENT OF URK. IV 733:4–7

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Abstract: *Urk. IV 733:4–7 is a brief but very intriguing passage from the Annals of Thutmose III. The passage describes a delivery of items from the land of tj-nꜣ-y, and provides the earliest known attestation of this (probably) Aegean toponym, while also providing the only surviving attestation of kft(j)w in the Annals, in reference to one of the items being delivered. Not surprisingly, this passage has often been mentioned in works and studies focusing on Egypt-Aegean interactions. However, the actual Egyptian wording of the passage has never been analysed or discussed in a detailed and systematic way, and as a result, the available translations usually reflect a rather superficial and somewhat approximate understanding of the text itself. The present article seeks to address this gap by providing a thorough reassessment of the text from both a linguistic and a sociocultural perspective. A framework for disambiguating translations and presenting multiple parallel interpretations will also be briefly introduced at the end.*

Keywords: *Urk. IV 733:4-7; Annals of Thutmose III; Tanaya; Keftiu*

1. Introduction



Urk. IV 733:4–7 is a passage from the Annals of Thutmose III that records a delivery of vessels from the land of *tj-nꜣ-y* – likely an Aegean region that is attested here for the first time in the Egyptian sources. This passage also provides the only attestation of *kft(j)w* in the Annals. As a result, it was mentioned in several works dealing with interactions between Egypt and the Aegean (see e.g., Vercoutter 1956, 55; Strange 1980, 96; Cline 1994, 114; Panagiotopoulos 2015; see also Wachsmann 1987). However, despite its evident historical interest, it has never been the object of any specific and detailed analyses, taking into consideration both its socio-historical context and its linguistic and philological peculiarities. Thus, most discussions around this text have been based on translations that, while generally fine, are not as accurate as one would like. Moreover, there is a considerable amount of information embedded in this text that has never been fully unpacked. This information is definitely worthy of attention, as it provides insights and valuable starting points for further discussion concerning several issues relevant to the study of Egyptian perceptions of and interactions with other societies. The present article thus has the dual goal of providing an accurate translation of this passage and of contextualising the most peculiar elements that characterise it within wider perspectives.

2. Context of the passage

Urk. IV 733:4–7 appears toward the end of the Annals of Thutmose III, as part of the entry recording the campaign of year 42, the final one in the surviving copy of the Annals; it is part of the section of the campaign entry that lists foreign deliveries and contributions. The passage is located after a lacuna that, in turn, is preceded by a mention of a delivery from Hatti. Because the dimensions of the lacuna are unclear (Redford 2003, 96), it is hard to say whether deliveries from other countries were mentioned there and are now lost, or if our passage directly followed the Hittite delivery. Following the passage are tributes and contributions from Nubia.

According to Urk IV 729:8, the year 42 campaign involved fighting around Irqata, a city located in the Akkar plain on the northern Lebanese coast (modern Tell Arqa), while the following lines

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mention fighting in the areas of Tunip (probably modern Tell Asharneh) and Qadesh (modern Tell Nebi Mend). Thus, the campaign appears to have taken place in the region of Amurru and the Orontes Valley between Tunip and Qadesh, and it is reasonable to think that the non-Nubian deliveries received in that year, including those mentioned in Urk. IV 733:4-7, the passage discussed here, were the result of encounters in that area.

As previously stated, this is the only point in the Annals in which *kft(j)w* and *tj-nꜣ-y* are mentioned, and it is intriguing that this mention appears towards the end of the reign of Thutmose III. Outside the Annals, Aegean envoys are also mentioned in a few contemporary tombs. One in particular, that of Rekhmire, deserves special attention. This tomb contains two distinct layers of depictions of Aegean envoys (see e.g., Vercoutter 1956, xiii–xiv, 2, passim; Wachsmann 1987, 33–34, passim). The first depicts a series of characters in a way that is very similar to comparable representations in previous tombs. It may thus have originally reflected a traditional, stereotypical motif that does not correspond to any specific contemporary encounter or event, as is likely the case for similar depictions in other tombs. However, at some point during the work, this first group of Aegean characters was erased and redrawn in a different and innovative manner.[2] This abrupt change has led to the general idea that the erasure of earlier, more traditional depictions, and the subsequent redefinition of the appearance of the Aegean characters in this tomb, may have been the consequence of a real encounter with Aegean envoys, resulting in an "update" of Egyptian ways of representing the Aegean people (see Wachsmann 1987, 33–34 and passim). It is certainly intriguing that this redefinition of the paintings in Rekhmire's tomb seems to have occurred near the end of Thutmose III's reign (see e.g., Wachsmann 1987, 104–5, 128–29)[3] – exactly like the delivery from the land of *tj-nꜣ-y* mentioned in the passage from the Annals discussed here. If such an interpretation of the redrawing of this tomb is correct, it would be tempting to see a correlation between these two observations, but, of course, one must be cautious given the scant nature of the evidence.

3. Previous translations

Previous scholars have suggested various translations for this passage, the most important of which are as follows:

Vercoutter (1956, 55):
"[Tribut du Chef] de Tinꜣy (une) cruche-shaouabty d'argent en travail du pays Keftiou, ainsi que quatre vases de cuivre à anses d'argent. En tout (lit. cela fait) 56 deben 3 kite (soit environ 5 kg. 120 gr.)."

Cline (1994, 114) following Strange (Strange 1980, 96):
"Tribute from the prince of Tanaya: a silver shawabti-vessel in Keftiuan workmanship together with four bowls of iron (copper?) with handles of silver"

Redford (2003, 96):
"[Benevolence of the chief] of Tanaya:
Silver: a jug of Keftiu workmanship along with vessels of iron
. . . with silver handle(s) 4, making 56 dbn, 3 kdt"

Panagiotopoulos (2015, 293)
"[gifts from the ruler] of *Tanaja*
a silver *shawabti*-vessel in *Keftiu* workmanship
along with bowls of metal with handles of silver: (total) 4
making 56 *dbn*, 3 *qdt*."

Overall, the general meaning of the passage is clear. However, all of these translations are problematic, both in terms of how they render the single elements and how they connect them to each other. In fact, the passage presents several points

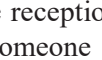
[2] These new figures are clearly stylistically related to those in the tomb of Mencheperresonb. The relative chronology of the representations in these two tombs, whether Rekhmire's representations follow Mencheperresonb's or vice versa (for discussion, see Wachsmann 1987, 33–34 and passim; see also Panagiotopoulos 2006), is not relevant here, because the crucial point is the redrawing of these people within the same scene, which is a characteristic unique to Rekhmire's tomb.

[3] Note that the present article is not concerned with the ethnic, cultural, or political identity/ies of the characters depicted in Rekhmire's tomb – what is relevant here are Wachsmann's considerations about the chronology and execution of these representations, regardless of whether one agrees or disagrees with him on the Minoans vs Mycenaeans issue.

of interest and problematic details that need or deserve to be individually discussed before suggesting any translation. The remainder of this article will, therefore, focus on this, first by analysing in detail the nine most relevant elements and then by discussing how the entire passage can be translated.

4. Urk. IV 733:4-7 – Analysis and translation

4.1. Urk. IV 733:4 [] = [*jnw n wr(w)*] *n tj-nꜣ-y*

4.1.1. The beginning of the text is lost, but the passage clearly consists of a rather standard entry recording the reception by the Egyptians of goods brought by someone from a land called  *tj-nꜣ-y*. However, due to the lacuna, we do not know which word the Egyptians used to refer to these goods. Sethe's reconstruction of *jnw* = "*jnw*-delivery/tribute" is certainly possible and perhaps even likely, as this is indeed the term commonly employed to refer to goods delivered by polities outside the Egyptian dominions.[4] However, other terms like *bꜣk* = "*bꜣk*-levy" cannot be fully discarded as this is the only entry in the Annals referring to the land called *tj-nꜣ-y*, and, therefore, we have no direct parallel for it that can help us determine the actual nature of its interactions with Egypt.

Similarly, we do not really know whether such goods were delivered by a (or many?) *wr(w)* = "political leader(s)" (for more on this term see Lorton 1974, 60–63) because that section of the text is also a reconstruction by Sethe. It is a possibility, but there is no certainty, and it should not be counted as an authentic attestation of such expression.[5]

4.2. Urk. IV 733:4 = *tj-nꜣ-y*

4.2.1. This is the earliest known attestation of the name *tj-nꜣ-y* in Egyptian sources, as well as the only one that appears in an actual textual passage (the five others are later attestations from laconic topographical lists).[6] The name *tj-nꜣ-y* has long been recognized as referring to some region in the Aegean. The form of the name has been compared with Greek Δαναοί = *Danaòi*, one of the names by which the Greeks were known. It has thus been interpreted as a reference to the "land of the Danaoi," and it has been suggested that it may have referred to the "Mycenaean" Peloponnese or, more specifically, to the region of Mycenae (Faure 1968, 145–47; Cline 1987, 3 with refs; 1994, 32; Edel and Görg 2005, 196–200; Cline and Stannish 2011, 7; Panagiotopoulos 2015, 298–99 with refs). However, in my opinion and as stated in previous scholarship (Edel and Görg 2005, 196–200), one must be cautious about the latter very specific geographical identification, primarily because it is based on the geopolitical reality of the region during the Iron Age, and such a reality may have changed (and certainly did change) a lot in the centuries that separate it from the Late Bronze Age Egyptian sources discussed here. Moreover, it should be stressed that there is a clear conceptual difference between the Greek word Δαναοί = *Danaòi* and the Egyptian *tj-nꜣ-y*, as the former refers to a *population*, while the latter clearly refers to a *region* or *country*. This is evident from the spelling of the word in Egyptian hieroglyphs: the word is spelled with the sign N25 = = [foreign land/country], which is a classifier[7] used to mark names of geographical and/or geopolitical entities.[8] This geographical/geopolitical name has no attested direct parallel in the Aegean. However, the final *-y-* of the Egyptian form is suggestive: Greek had a very productive suffix *-ΐ̔ᾱ = -íā* that was used to create toponyms, and it would be tempting to consider the Egyptian *tj-nꜣ-y* as a transcription of an hypothetical Greek form **Dana-íā* = "land of the Danaoi" (see Cline 1987, 3 with refs to similar suggestions). However, to my knowledge, no such **Dana-íā* = "land of the Danaoi" is attested in any Greek source.

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4 For discussions and analyses of the *jnw* and *bꜣk* deliveries/contributions, see e.g., Kruchten 1980; Bleiberg 1984; 1988; 1996; Gordon 1984; 1998; Janssen 1993; Galán 1995, 40:66; Quirke 1998; Liverani 2001, 176–82.

5 As instead e.g., Cline does (1994, 85).

6 Namely, 3 from the reign of Amenhotep III from the temple of Amun at Soleb, from the base of a statue at Kom el-Hetan, and from the base of another statue next to the Tenth Pylon in Karnak, and 2 from the reign of Ramses II from the Temple of Aksha and from the Temple of Amara West. Both of the latter Ramesside lists are simply copies of Amenhotep III's list at Soleb (for references and discussion see Cline 1994, 114–16).

7 Classifiers are signs that were added at the ends of words to provide a visual reference to the semantic domains associated by the Egyptians with those specific words. For a discussion of the classifier system in Egyptian, see e.g., Goldwasser 2002. If the word was the name of a population or group of people of some kind, a different set of classifiers would have been expected, such as  or  .

At any rate, it is clear that the Egyptians interpreted the term as a geographical/geopolitical name, and this is what should matter here, as we are dealing with an Egyptian text reflecting an Egyptian worldview. For these reasons, and to stress this nuance, I suggest translating the Egyptian word  *tj-nꜣ-y* as "land/country called *tj-nꜣ-y*".

4.3. Urk. IV 733:5  = *kft(j)w*

4.3.1. This name has been the subject of much debate over the years (for a recent overview with refs, see: Matić 2012; 2014). Suffice to say that the current general consensus regards it as a term referring to Crete, and according to some authors, to Minoan Crete.[9]

It is important to note here[10] that the word *kft(j)w* is written with the classifier N25 =  = [foreign land/country], and thus specifically refers to a *land* or *country*, not to a *population*, as in the case of *tj-nꜣ-y*. So not "*kft(j)w* people," but rather a "Land called *kft(j)w*." This is not simply a quirk of our text: *all* known attestations of the word *kft(j)w* are written with the classifier N25 = = [foreign land/country], and thus can be safely understood as referring to a geographical or geopolitical space, rather than to a group of people. In other words, Egyptian sources make no mention of "*kft(j)w* people,"[11] only of a "land/country called *kft(j)w*."[12] At most, one can find references to people *related to* or *coming from* the land/country called *kft(j)w*.[13]

4.3.2. This observation deserves to be contextualised within a broader perspective. It is clear that the expressions the Egyptians used in their texts are likely to directly or indirectly reflect their way of perceiving, understanding, and conceiving the world around them. In this respect, it is worth noting that there is no evidence of any strict, exclusive, and regular 1:1 association between specific lands and specific populations or ethnic groups in the Egyptian sources of the New Kingdom. On the contrary, there are clear instances of terms referring to specific populations[14] that do not appear to match any specific geographical/geopolitical names,[15] while on the other hand, there are also several examples of geographical/geopolitical names that cannot be associated with any specific group or population.[16]

Moreover, rather than being pure toponyms describing purely geographical realities, some of the terms classified with N25 = = [foreign land/country] may actually have to be understood as referring to specific *geo-political* entities characterised by one or more political leaders who were recognised by Egyptians as their *wr(w)* = "political leader(s)." For instance, Egyptians may have understood = *ḫtꜣ* = "Hatti" primarily as a *geo-politically* defined entity in a way that may approximate our concept of "state" or "country" – a *political entity* that:

a. controlled a specific geographical territory, i.e., a specific *tꜣ n ḫtꜣ* = "land of/belonging to Hatti" (e.g., Pap. Anastasi I 18:7)

[8] For the distinction between geographical and geopolitical, see below, under *kft(j)w*.

[9] For a recent discussion and thorough deconstruction of this association, see Matić 2012.

[10] As already noted (but rarely discussed) by other scholars for other attestations of this word (see e.g., Matić 2012, 236).

[11] For a discussion of the genesis of this misreading, and for a review of earlier assumptions regarding *kft(j)w*, see Matić 2012.

[12] Note that although clumsy, the translation "land/country called *kft(j)w*" is preferable to "*kft(j)w*-land," as the latter is potentially ambiguous in English: "*kft(j)w*-land" could in fact be understood as "the land that is *kft(j)w*" (on the model of "Greenland" or "Netherlands"), or "the land of the *kft(j)w*-thing" (on the model of "Portland" or "Iceland"), or as "the land of the *kft(j)w*-people" (on the model of most toponyms built with "–land" in English, like "England", "Scotland", etc.). The latter being the most common, it is also likely to be the default interpretation for a translation "*kft(j)w*-land," which would be problematic considering what is argued here.

[13] See e.g., the mentions of *wrw kft(j)w* = "political leaders of the land/country called *kft(j)w*" in texts from various Egyptian tombs of the New Kingdom (see Cline 1994, 108–14).

[14] Which may have been defined by the perception of a common ethnicity or by other common sociocultural features such as shared language, religion, etc.

[15] E.g.: *mḏꜣy* = "Medjay people," *ꜥꜣmw* = "Levantine people," *šꜣsw* = "Shasu people," as well as the groups that make up the so-called "Sea People" who are located on vague "islands in the sea".

[16] E.g., *rmnn* = possibly "Lebanon"; *ḏꜣ-h(ʾ)* = possibly the Levantine coast perhaps including *rmnn*; *rtnw* = the (inner?) Levant and Syria; etc.

b. and extended its political control over cities such as *tnp n ḫtꜣ* = "Tunip of Hatti" (e.g., KRI V 78:15),[17]
c. that was the domain of a *wr (ꜥꜣ) n ḫtꜣ* = "(great) ruler of Hatti" (e.g., KRI II 226:8),
d. who, in turn, ruled over the population(s) living in the territory of such a (geo)political entity, which could be referred to with expressions like *rmṯ tꜣ ḫtꜣ* = "people(s) of the land of/belonging to Hatti" (KRI II 252:1),[18] an expression that most likely has to be understood as the "people(s) of the Hatti *state*" as a whole, regardless of how ethno-culturally diverse and distinct they may have perceived themselves.

Obviously, it has to be stressed once again that this is how the Egyptians portrayed these realities, not necessarily how the people who actually formed those realities saw themselves. However, it is worth noting here that such a framework, which defined communal identities based on (geo)political realities and relations, was not unique to ancient Egypt and is attested in other ancient Eastern Mediterranean traditions. For instance, according to Greek traditions,[19] the Danaoi mentioned above were originally the people *ruled by* a man called Danaos.[20]

4.3.3. To sum up, it is clear that the Egyptians had a quite complex perception of the people(s) and inhabited spaces around them, involving several, variously overlapping layers[21] – and this is the frame, the "cosmography," against which the term "*kft(j)w*" should be understood.

From this perspective, the fact that this term is attested with the classifier N25 = 𓈙 = [FOREIGN LAND] and never with a classifier implying a "*kft(j)w*-people," combined with the occasional mention of *wr(w)* = "political leader(s)" associated with it, suggests that the Egyptians may have conceived of *kft(j)w* as a term referring to a geographical area or even to a geopolitical entity with one or more specific rulers. At the same time, this also means that the term does not refer to any specific community, and so provides no information about how Egyptians perceived the people and populations inhabiting such a region, let alone how such people perceived themselves. This is most likely not an accident, but rather a reflex of the (official) way Egyptians viewed the world beyond their borders during the reign of Thutmose III.

4.3.4. In other words, while the questions of "who" and "what" the people inhabiting *kft(j)w* were may be of relevance to modern scholars, they do not appear to have been as crucial to the Egyptians, at least in the context of such inscriptions. Therefore, to avoid ambiguities and the false impression of a connection with any specific population, I would suggest translating the term *kft(j)w* as "land/country called *kft(j)w*" or, when attributive, "of the land/country called *kft(j)w*," rather than using less clumsy but also less accurate translations such as "*kft(j)w*-land" or "Keftian".

4.4. Urk. IV 733:5  = *m bꜣk n kft(j)w*

4.4.1. The expression *m bꜣk n kft(j)w* can be translated as "in the workmanship of the land/country called *kft(j)w*", which is likely to be understood as "in the artisanal/artistic tradition/style" of such land/country (see also PANAGIOTOPOULOS 2015, 299–301). The consonantal root √*b-ꜣ-k* is associated with the concept of "working;" words derived from it include *bꜣk* = "to work", "to serve", or *bꜣkt* = "revenue", "result of work." The expression is not unique to this passage; it can also be found in the following passages of the Annals:

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[17] Note that Tunip was a Western Syrian city conquered by the Hittites from Mitanni. It was not an originally "Hittite" city, and, to my knowledge, there is no evidence that Hittites were ever an important component of the local population.

[18] See also KRI II 251:2, where *rmṯ nb<t> tꜣ ḫtꜣ* = "all the people(s) of the land of/belonging to Hatti" appears in contrast to *<n>ꜣ kmt* = "the ones of the Black Land/Country (= Egypt)".

[19] Whether it is a historically accurate tradition or a later folk-etymology is unimportant for the present argument, because the existence of such a tradition implies that such a possibility was considered probable and conceivable.

[20] See Euripides fr. 228 = 1 A (HARDER 2018, 179–90): "Πελασγιώτας δ'ωνομασμένους το πριν, Δαναούς καλείσθαι νόμον έθηκ' αν' Ελλάδα" = "And (as for) those who before were called the Pelasgiotes, he (Danaos, after settling in Greece) established the custom to call them Danaoi (after himself) everywhere in Greece."

[21] This system merits further exploration, but is beyond the scope of the current paper. However, the present author is currently working on a separate paper that addresses this question in greater depth.

 *j-kꜣ-nꜣ ʿꜣ m bꜣk n ḫꜣ-rw* = "big *j-kꜣ-nꜣ* vessel(s) in the workmanship of the land/country called *ḫꜣ-rw*" (Urk. IV 665:16)

 *ḥnw m bꜣk n ḏꜣ-hʸ* = "*ḥnw*-vessel(s) in the workmanship of the land/country called *ḏꜣ-hʸ*" (Urk. IV 699:8)

 *ḥnw m bꜣk nb n ḏꜣ-hʸ* = "*ḥnw*-vessel(s) in all workmanship(s) of the land/country called *ḏꜣ-hʸ*" (Urk. IV 718:2)

 *ḥnw m bꜣk nb n ḫꜣst* = "various (*ḥnw*-)vessel(s) in the workmanship(s) of (a/the) foreign land/country (= Retenu?)" (Urk. IV 706:6)

All these attestations follow the same pattern, which can be summarised as [*m bꜣk (n)*] + [(NAME OF) FOREIGN LAND/COUNTRY].

4.4.2. It is worth noting the use of geographical/geopolitical names: in general, one may think that artisanal and artistic styles were associated with specific *communities* or *populations*, or even *ethnic groups*. This, however, was not what the Egyptians were doing, at least not in these passages of the Annals. Rather, *all* the attestations of this expression suggest that the Egyptians defined workmanship and "styles" according to a geographical/geopolitical frame, rather than to a sociocultural or "ethnic" one,[22] and this impression is confirmed by the attestation in Urk. IV 706:6 where the word *ḫꜣst* = "foreign land/country" is used. Is this really surprising? Perhaps not, or at least it should not be: when we consider our own modern reality, it is easy to see that, while we do associate some styles and "workmanship" with specific ethnically or socio-culturally defined communities, in many other cases we actually define them primarily or even exclusively through geographical/geopolitical frames. When we talk of "Swiss watches," "American jeans," "Damascus glass," or even "Lebanese food," we are actually associating the "workmanship" producing these goods with specific geographical regions or countries, rather than with any of the several populations inhabiting such places. This framing often reflects either a lack of familiarity with (or interest in) the actual demographic and sociocultural associations that characterise those specific lands,[23] or the recognition that such "workmanship" is shared by several distinct populations inhabiting those geographical/geopolitical spaces. In fact, the idea that material culture traditions may be associated with geographical/geopolitical places rather than with variously defined populations should be quite straightforward for archaeologists, not only because "pots are not people," but also because archaeological cultures, i.e., collections of items sharing a common "workmanship" usually have rather specific geographical distributions, and are often named after specific sites or regions.[24] There is no reason to assume that such a system is a prerogative of our modern societies; in fact, the attestations of the expression *m bꜣk (n)* suggest that the Egyptians shared a similar conceptual frame, at least in the specific context of the Annals.[25]

4.5. Urk IV 733:5  = *šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ*

4.5.1. The first item listed among the goods received from the "land/country called *tj-nꜣ-y*" is a *šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ* vessel,[26] which, as seen, is "in the workmanship of the land/country called *kft(j)w*." This word presents several points of interest and raises theoretical and conceptual issues, ranging from the word's actual form and origin to the Egyptian

[22] And, while there may be some ambiguity in the case of *ḫꜣ-rw*, as one may wonder if it must be read as the "land of the Hurrians," there is none at all in the case of *ḏꜣ-hʸ*, as *ḏꜣ-hʸ* is well attested in Egyptian sources, and it is always attested exclusively as a geographical/geopolitical name. In fact, the phrasing *bꜣk nb* = "all workmanship(s)" may suggest that, at least in Egyptian eyes, multiple "styles" coexisted within the land/country called *ḏꜣ-hʸ)*.

[23] For instance, in Switzerland, it is well known that watchmaking is a traditional industry practiced primarily, if not exclusively by a few specific French-speaking communities. But outside Switzerland: who cares? Since the watches come from *somewhere* in Switzerland, they are Swiss watches in general – and that is usually enough.

[24] See for instance definitions like "Helladic pottery" or "Kura-Araxes culture," to mention two examples.

[25] Following this reasoning, one may also argue that, for instance, the so-called *kft(j)ww*-ships and *kbnt*-ships should be understood as "ships of the type common in the land/country called *kft(j)w*" and "ships of the type common in the land/country of Byblos" (obviously, according to the Egyptian perception of these types and these ships), rather than as "*kft(j)w*-an (or worse "Minoan") ships" or "Byblian ships," as already variously suggested in previous scholarship.

[26] The consonantal part of the word is spelled like a rare New Kingdom spelling of the word *(w)šbty* = "(u)shabty," "funerary figurine" (only one attestation of this spelling is attested in the *Thesaurus Linguae Aegyptiae*). This spelling for "(u)shabty" is definitely unusual: perhaps it was influenced by the spelling of our word *šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ*-vessel?

perception and understanding of it in the context of the Annals. These aspects will be explored in the following paragraphs.

4.5.2. The classifier, W9 = 𓎛 = [JUG-LIKE VESSEL], clearly shows that the term refers to a vessel, possibly a sort of jug. This is the only known attestation of this word in Egyptian hieroglyphic texts. However, the same word likely appears once in the Amarna letter EA 14 iii 61, spelled in cuneiform as *šu-i-ib-ta₂*. Based on the comparison between the hieroglyphic and cuneiform spellings, the word can be reconstructed as **šVwibtV* or something similar.[27]

4.5.3. The origin of the word needs attention. As mentioned, the term appears in the Amarna Letter EA 14, which is a list of items sent by the Egyptian king to the king of Babylon. It is thus clear that EA 14 is not a letter sent *from* the Levant *to* Egypt, but rather (an administrative copy of?) a letter or inventory written *in* Egypt to be sent abroad. Moreover, although EA 14 is written in Akkadian, the word *šu-i-ib-ta₂* is not attested in any other Akkadian text (GELB et al. 1956, 17:211), and hence can hardly be assumed to be a genuine Akkadian word. Rather, it is reasonable to assume that this form *šu-i-ib-ta₂* is a transcription of an Egyptian word used by an Egyptian scribe to refer to a vessel that was being sent from Egypt. The relevant context in which the word is attested in EA 14 supports this interpretation, as the passage reads: 1 *ku-ku-bu ša* NA₄ *šu-i-ib-ta₂ šum-šu* = "1 *kukubu*-vessel of stone, *šu-i-ib-ta₂* is its name," where "its name" has to be understood as "its Egyptian name," as it is clear from similar expressions in the same letter, where "its name" refers unambiguously to Egyptian words.[28]

4.5.4. The story, however, does not end here. Although in the Amarna period the word can reasonably be assumed to be Egyptian (as in "being part of the Egyptian lexicon at the time"), its actual origins are not clear: the word does not have a clear Egyptian etymology, and in fact it likely was, ultimately, a loanword *into* Egyptian.[29] More specifically, it has been suggested that the word may have a Semitic origin, deriving from the Semitic root √šʔb = "to draw water" (HOCH 1994, 275), although no ʔ seems to be indicated by the Egyptian spelling.

4.5.5. So, coming back to our passage in the Annals, we have an Egyptian word of possibly foreign (perhaps Semitic) origin being used to refer to a vessel "in the workmanship of the land/country called *kft(j)w*" brought by someone from the "land/country called *tj-nꜣ-y*." How can we understand all this? Assuming that the word *šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ* is ultimately Semitic, are the Egyptians receiving vessels originating/produced in a Semitic-speaking context from people of the "land/country called *tj-nꜣ-y*"? And if so, are the people of the "land/country called *tj-nꜣ-y*" playing the role of middlemen between Egypt and Semitic speaking communities producing such vessels? Or are the people of the "land/country called *tj-nꜣ-y*" Semitic speakers themselves? And what about the "workmanship of the land/country called *kft(j)w*"? And above all, are any of these questions legitimate? Or in other words, does the passage in question imply any of this in the first place?

The answer to this last question is: it depends. In principle, indeed it could, but in this specific case (and perhaps in the specific case of Egypt in general), it probably does not.

Far from being trivial, this question is conceptually and theoretically very interesting. The issue is best illustrated with a practical example: consider the words "*sabre*" and "*katana*." Both are loanwords in English, with "*sabre*" coming from the French *sabre*[30] and "*katana*" from the Japanese 刀: *katana*. Both refer to weapons, to typologically similar swords with single-edged and usually slightly curved blades with single-edged and usually slightly curved blades. The "actual meaning"[31] of these words, however, differs slightly but significantly:

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[27] Where *V* = an undetermined unstressed vowel. Note that the hieroglyphic spelling with *-wꜣ-* suggests that the cuneiform šu-i-ib- should be understood as *šwib-, or as *šəwib-, rather than as *šuʔib-.

[28] E.g., EA 14 iii 61 *ku-iḫ-ku* = Egyptian *kꜣ-ḥr-kꜣ*.

[29] And the borrowing must have obviously occurred before year 42 of Thutmose III, as the attestation in the Annals counts as a *terminus ante quem*.

[30] Which in turn has a rather interesting history, as it is usually assumed to be from < German *Säbel* < Polish *szabla* < Hungarian *szablya* < Turkic (cf. Kyrgiz and Kipchak) *selebe*, which in turn is possibly from a Tungusic language like Manchu *seleme* = "dagger".

[31] I use this expression for lack of a better term; one should understand it as "actual meaning" = "perception native speakers have of what these two words refer to when used in English."

i. On the one hand, the term "*sabre*" in English can be used to describe any kind of sword that shares such typological characteristics, with no implicit cultural connotation and certainly no privileged or exclusive association with French culture, or any of the several cultures through which the word passed before reaching French.
ii. In contrast, the word *"katana"* in English usually refers to a specifically Japanese or Japanese-style sword characterised by such typological characteristics.

So, essentially, *"sabre"* has lost any association with its source culture (or any of the cultures it passed through), and English speakers use it as a simple, culturally neutral typological term. In contrast, *"katana"* retains specific cultural connotations linking it to Japan, where the word ultimately originates, and it is usually employed to describe swords that are recognised and perceived as being somewhat connected to the Japanese cultural tradition in their actual (manufacturing) origin and/or in their appearance and style.[32]

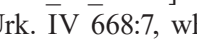
So, in the case of our passage from the Annals, the actual question is whether the word *šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ* should be understood as a *sabre*-like loanword, or as a *katana*-like loanword, namely as a purely typological term with no cultural connotation, or as a term with cultural connotations which was understood and associated, in the Egyptian mind, with some specific West-Semitic speaking community/ies. Given that this is the only attestation of the word in hieroglyphic texts,[33] in principle, this question cannot be answered conclusively. However, a few observations regarding how other loanwords are used in this kind of Egyptian texts, and in Egyptian in general, suggest that *šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ* is as a *sabre*-like loanword with no specific cultural connotation. More specifically, a very interesting parallel is provided by the word *m-ḏꜣ-rꜣ(-nꜣ)*, a term referring to some kind of weapon that appears lists of booties in two royal inscriptions of Merenptah (KRI IV 9:9; KRI IV 22:15), a context thus very similar to the passage from the Annals discussed here. *m-ḏꜣ-rꜣ(-nꜣ)* appears to be a Levantine loanword in Egyptian, possibly ultimately of Hurrian origin (Hoch 1994, 178). Still, in the texts of Merenptah, *m-ḏꜣ-rꜣ(-nꜣ)* refers to weapons captured by the Egyptians in a battle against the Libyans. Now, Libyans and Hurrian-speaking populations were located on opposite sides of the Egyptian empire, and there is no evidence whatsoever of any contact between them or of any historical situation in which such contact might have occurred. It is thus extremely unlikely that the Egyptians captured weapons originating in a Hurrian-speaking milieu. It is far more plausible that the Egyptians used the word *m-ḏꜣ-rꜣ(-nꜣ)* in a purely generic sense, referring to Libyan weapons that appeared to them to be *m-ḏꜣ-rꜣ(-nꜣ)* weapons – with no cultural connotation implied in the word itself. Furthermore, despite the fact that several loanwords are known to have lost their culturally specific connotations and were commonly used to refer to fully Egyptian realities (see Hoch 1994), I was unable to find any clear example of a *katana*-like loanword in any comparable textual context.[34] It thus seems reasonable to assume that the Egyptians employed words like *šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ* to typologically (not culturally) describe a specific type of vessel.

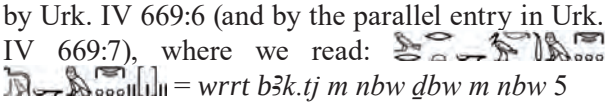
4.5.6. Another distinct issue is the quantity of *šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ*-like vessels involved in the transaction recorded in the Annals passage discussed here. All the above-mentioned scholars assumed that there was only one *šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ*-like vessel, but none discussed this assumption; one might speculate that they simply read *šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ* as a singular, and thus presumed that no numeral was expressly spelled out because only one item was involved. This possibility cannot be excluded. Other entries in the Annals, however, clearly show that even when only one item was involved, quantities were

[32] Note that all this has to be read as being specifically from the perspective of English speakers, according to *their own* idea and idealization of what a "Japanese" and "Japanese-style" item is – a Japanese person may have very different ideas about what "Japanese", "Japanese-style" (and "Japanese katana") mean.

[33] And considering that obviously we cannot ask any 18th dynasty Egyptian for their perception as "native speaker".

[34] I am talking here specifically about loanwords referring to objects and items, for which I could not find any unambiguous examples of *katana*-like loanwords. By contrast, *katana*-like loanwords do exist in relation to other semantic domains, such as terms referring to foreign titles or foreign types of troops – see e.g., *mryn* = "mariannu," which is used primarily if not exclusively to refer to Levantine people, or *nᶜrn* = a kind of troop mentioned only in Levantine contexts. Reviewer #1 suggested, perhaps, the word *ktp* (Hoch nr. 500), which is attested only once, as a weapon of the god Baʿal. It is indeed a tempting candidate, although uncertain; the salient feature here might be the association of such a weapon (also in Levantine sources) with the god Baʿal, rather than its Levantine origins.

explicitly written out using the standard pattern [MATERIAL + OBJECT(S)_MADE_OF_THE_MATERIAL + NR_OF_ITEMS]. This is evident, for example, in Urk. IV 668:7, where we read  = *ḫsbd jnr ꜥꜣ 1* = "lapis lazuli: big stone : 1."[35] At the same time, there are a few entries where numerals are absent. Some of these cases refer to batches of items whose exact quantity was unknown or irrelevant. Others make it clear that more than one item was involved by using plural strokes in their spellings (see e.g., ) or through words like *ꜥšꜣ* = "many" or šbn = "various." Finally, there are cases that are (hopelessly?) ambiguous, in which no quantity is specified (neither 1 nor >1), and no explicit marker of plurality is present. In such cases, whether what was meant was *one* item or an *unspecified quantity* of items is objectively difficult to decide. For instance, it might be reasonable to understand the entry  = *ḥḏ j-kꜣ-nꜣ ddwt* in Urk. IV 717:16 as referring to "*Silver: one j-kꜣ-nꜣ* vessel and *many ddwt* plates," as *ddwt* is written with the plural strokes while there is nothing implying or even suggesting plurality for *j-kꜣ-nꜣ*. At the same time, one wonders about the  *ḥḏ ddt j-kꜣ-nꜣ ḫnmt ḥr n kꜣ(?) ḥnw šbn* 325 = "silver: *ddt*-dish(es), *j-kꜣ-nꜣ*-vessel(s), *ḫnmt*-vessel(s),[36] a head of bull (a rhyton vessel?), various vessels = 325 (items)" (Urk IV 722:3-4), since taking them all as singulars would suggest a strangely unbalanced list of 1 *ddt*-dish, 1 *j-kꜣ-nꜣ*-vessel, 1 *ḫnmt*-vessel, 1 head of bull (a rhyton vessel?) and 321 other various vessels – a doubt Redford (2003, 90) must also have had, because he translated *ddt* as plural, as "dishes."

An even more suspicious example is provided by Urk. IV 669:6 (and by the parallel entry in Urk. IV 669:7), where we read:  = *wrrt bꜣk.tj m nbw ḏbw m nbw* 5

We do not know exactly what the *ḏbw* are, but they are chariot components. Should we thus understand this as "5 chariots worked in gold, (with) *ḏbw* made of/worked in gold," with the 5 referring to the "chariots," which, despite the singular spelling, must be understood as plural? Or should we understand it as "*a* chariot (singular) worked in gold, (with) 5 *ḏbw* made of/worked in gold?" In fact, both interpretations support the idea that singular spellings may refer to multiple items because *wrrt* and *ḏbw* are both spelled as singular, yet the entry clearly states that there are 5 items involved. In this case, however, there is an interesting parallel worth considering. In Urk. IV 663:12-13 we read "*wrrt bꜣk.tj m nbw ḏbw m nbw n ḫr pf* 1" = "chariot worked in gold, (with) *ḏbw* made of/worked in gold, of that fallen one = 1." This parallel is important not only because it provides another example in which the presence of a single item is explicitly spelled out with the numeral 1, but also because it suggests that the numeral 1 refers to the chariot and not to the *ḏbw*, and at the same time may suggest that chariots had only 1 *ḏbw*. All this suggests that the reading "5 chariots worked in gold, (with) *ḏbw* made of/worked in gold (possibly one each)" is probably preferable. This in turn seems to indicate that apparently singular spellings may indeed refer to multiple items – or, at least, that singular spellings cannot be automatically assumed to refer to only one item.

šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ appears to be one of those ambiguous cases. On the one hand, it would be tempting to take the apparently singular spelling as implying that only one *šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ*-like vessel was exchanged, but the intrinsic ambiguity of these forms calls for caution.

4.5.7. Thus to sum up, *šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ* can be translated as "*šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ*-like vessel(s)", and the entire passage *šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ m bꜣk n kft(j)w* can be translated as "*šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ*-like vessel(s) in the workmanship of the land/country called *kft(j)w*."

4.6. Urk IV 733:6  = *ḥnw*

4.6.1. The use of the classifiers W24-W22-Z2 =  = [VARIOUS/UNSPECIFIED VESSEL(S)] suggests that the word = *ḥnw* should be understood as a generic "vessels of various types", "various vessels", "vessels (in general)."[37]

4.7. Urk IV 733:6  = *n bjꜣ*

4.7.1. This apparently simple passage presents two problems.

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[35] See also Urk IV 686:4; 691:4.

[36] Redford (2003, 90) did not take *ḫnmt* as referring to a type of vessel, but rather took it as a form of the verb *ḫnm* = "to join"; "to build" and translated as "Silver: dishes and a mixing cauldron adorned with a bull's head and various vessels."

[37] Note that the word is very common in the Annals, see also above in the discussion of *m bꜣk n*.

4.7.2. The first issue lies in the *n*, which is rather ambiguous. Its primary meanings are "to"/"for" or "belonging to"/"of"/"pertaining to." However, *n* can also be used to mean "made of" when followed by a material,[38] even though the preposition *m* appears to be more common in this function (see e.g., in this very passage *ḏrt m ḥḏ* = "handle(s) of silver").

4.7.3. The second problem lies in the word *bjꜣ*, which is attested in several different contexts across all periods of Egyptian history, with at least 5 different meanings identified.

Two of these meanings, *bjꜣ* = "heaven" and *bjꜣ* = "mining region" can be excluded from the discussion of the present passage of the Annals, the first because it makes no sense in this context, and the second because it is usually written with the classifier N25 = = [FOREIGN LAND/COUNTRY], which is not present here.

The other three meanings are:

1. *bjꜣ* = "metal (in general)"
   Previous scholars have translated the word *bjꜣ* as "iron" (REDFORD 2003, 96), "iron (copper?)" (CLINE 1994, 114) and "copper" (VERCOUTTER 1956, 55). Indeed, one of the primary meanings of *bjꜣ* is clearly related to metals. However, I believe both the abovementioned suggestions are inaccurate because they are too specific,[39] and the word should be translated generically as "metal" (as done in PANAGIOTOPOULOS 2015, 293).
   But let us have a look at the data. It is true that *bjꜣ* has been used to refer to the substance meteors are made of since the Old Kingdom, and it is also true that metallic meteors are usually made of iron or iron alloys (ALMANSA-VILLATORO, 2019). However, in these contexts *bjꜣ* usually appears as part of the fixed expression *bjꜣ n pt* = "*bjꜣ* of the sky" – an expression that survives in Coptic as (S) ⲃⲉⲛⲓⲡⲉ <benipe>, which indeed means "iron" (VYCICHL 1984, 30). This Coptic form is important because it demonstrates that the expression *bjꜣ n pt* as a whole, rather than *bjꜣ* alone, denoted "iron." In fact, the word *bjꜣ* is not attested in isolation in Coptic, but appears as the first element in a few other names of metals, such as: ⲃⲁⲣⲱⲧ <barōt> = "brass, bronze" (VYCICHL 1984, 30), ⲃⲁⲥⲛⲟ <basnkⁱ> = "tin" (VYCICHL 1984, 32), ⲃⲁⲥⲟⲩⲣ <basūr> = "antimony" (VYCICHL 1984, 32). These words suggest that the element ⲃⲉ-/ⲃⲁ- works in Coptic as a prefix for metal terms, and the consensus in the Coptological literature is to understand it as meaning simply "metal (in general, of any kind)" (besides VYCICHL 1984, passim, see e.g., the note in *Coptic Dictionary Online* no. C545). It seems to me that the same can be assumed for its (Late) Egyptian antecedent: *bjꜣ* would thus mean "metal (in general, of any kind)," while specific metals were referred to using composite expressions, such as *bjꜣ n pt* = "metal of the sky" = "iron".
2. *bjꜣ* = a kind of stone?
   There are a few attestations, mainly from the Book of the Dead, where *bjꜣ* seems to be the material of bricks/blocks (*ḏbt*). If this *bjꜣ* is not the same as the previous one (in which case *ḏbt* may refer to metal ingots, as in the Annals, e.g., in Urk. IV 692:8), then it may refer to some kind of stone, as suggested by the TLA (DZA 22.817.670; DZA 22.817.720).[40] The classifier O39 =  = [CUT STONE/BRICK], often used in the spelling of *bjꜣ*, may support such an interpretation.
3. *bjꜣ* = substance mentioned in offering lists
   Some offering lists mention a product called *bjꜣ*.[41] This *bjꜣ* is often qualified as "Upper Egyptian *bjꜣ*" and "Lower Egyptian *bjꜣ*." Moreover, in some texts it seems to be related to

[38] For a clear example in the Annals, see Urk. IV 707:2:  = *ḫnw n ḫmt* = "vessels of copper".

[39] And it is highly unlikely that Egyptians received iron vessels in the early 15th century, as there is no evidence in the region for the metallurgical technology that would have been required to produce them at the time and for centuries afterwards.

[40] See also *jnr n bjꜣt* = "stone of (the?) *bjꜣt*" in pChester Beatty IV, v° 7, 7, which is translated as "quartzite" in the *Ramses* database. Note that the word here is an apparently feminine *bjꜣt* not the usual masculine *bjꜣ*. However, this kind of variation in gender is not unusual in Late Egyptian.

[41] See the TLA (note that some are duplicates): DZA 22.817.790; DZA 22.817.800; DZA 22.817.810; DZA 22.817.820; DZA 22.817.830; DZA 22.817.840; DZA 22.817.850; DZA 22.817.860; DZA 22.817.870; DZA 22.817.890; DZA 22.817.900; DZA 22.817.910; DZA 22.817.920; DZA 22.817.930; DZA 22.817.950; DZA 22.817.960; DZA 22.817.970; DZA 22.817.980; DZA 22.817.990; DZA 22.818.000; DZA 22.818.010; DZA 22.818.020; DZA 22.818.030; DZA 22.818.040; DZA 22.818.050.

(shaped as?) the ritual instrument *sb*, while in many others it seems to qualify beer. Attestations begin in the Old Kingdom and continue in the following periods. Some are known from the reign of Thutmose III and the early 18th dynasty, where *bjꜣ* appears in association with beer.[42] This *bjꜣ* is often presented in *ḥnw*-vessels. This *bjꜣ* is unlikely to be the same thing as nrs 1 or 2: goods on those offering lists tend to be consumables such as food, drinks, oils, or incense - metals or stones are not what one would expect.[43] It is worth mentioning here that some New Kingdom administrative documents record some *šʿy bjꜣ* - "sand/powder of *bjꜣ*" (O. Gardiner 0166 r 6 = KRI III 550:9; O. Cairo 25504 v I:3; O. UC 39630 r I:11; O. UC 39630 r II:15; P. Turin Cat. 1898 + 1926 + 1937 + 2094; P. Turin Cat. 2094/244 r 2,8; = KRI VI 690:8). This has been translated as "metal powder" or "iron powder" (so does the *Ramses* database – see the entries for the texts just mentioned, respectively *Ramses* IDs 804, 54, 3906, 3906, 4278), but I wonder if these are actually references to the *bjꜣ* substance in the offering lists.[44] The attestation in O. UC 39630 r I:11 may be relevant in this regard: this ostracon contains a list of various food items distributed to several people, and *šʿy bjꜣ* appears among such deliveries – this may support the idea that *šʿy bjꜣ* was some kind of consumable, rather than "metal powder." The classifier A2 =  = [MOUTH-RELATED ACTIVITIES] used to classify *bjꜣ* in the attestation of *šʿy bjꜣ* in KRI III 550:9 may also support this hypothesis, although other explanations are also possible (beginning with a scribe's error, perhaps influenced by some similarly sounding words). At any rate, one might offer some guesses regarding the composition of this substance, but the sources are likely too scarce and vague to provide a conclusive answer.

4.7.4. Combining the possible meanings of the preposition *n* with the possible meanings of *bjꜣ*, yields two main groups of translations. The first option is to translate *n bjꜣ* as "made of *bjꜣ*". In this case, both the meanings 1. and 2. of *bjꜣ* may be valid candidates, thus resulting in *ḥnw n bjꜣ* = "(*ḥnw*-) vessels made of metal" or "(*ḥnw*-)vessels made of *bjꜣ*-stone." The second option is to translate *n bjꜣ* as "of/for the *bjꜣ*". In this second case, the meaning 2. and 3. look more suitable, thus giving: *ḥnw n bjꜣ* = "(*ḥnw*-)vessels for/of the *bjꜣ*-stone" or "(*ḥnw*-)vessels for/of the *bjꜣ*-substance." Personally, I think the first option, "(*ḥnw*-)vessels made of metal" is the most likely. However, I do not see any conclusive argument to fully discard the others.

4.8. Urk IV 733:6  = *ḏrt m ḥḏ*

4.8.1. The expression  = *ḏrt m ḥḏ* literally means "hand(s) of silver," but since it refers to the previous vessels, it probably means "handles of silver."[45] This element's syntax is somewhat ambiguous. Parallels elsewhere in the Annals show that the subpattern [PART-OF-OBJECT + *m* + MATERIAL] can be inserted just before the numerals, indicating quantities to specify the corresponding entry. For instance, Urk. IV 669:6 and Urk. IV 669:7 provide examples of the pattern [MATERIAL + OBJECT(S)_MADE_OF_THE_MATERIAL + NR_OF_ITEMS] being extended by the subpattern [PART-OF-OBJECT + *m* + MATERIAL], thus resulting in complex patterns [MATERIAL + OBJECT(S)_MADE_OF_THE_MATERIAL + [PART-OF-OBJECT + *m* + MATERIAL] + NR_OF_ITEMS]:

 = *wrrt bꜣk.tj m nbw ḏbw m nbw* 5

 = *wrrt bꜣk.tj m nbw ḏbw m ʿgt* 5

"Chariot(s) worked in gold, with pole(s) (made of/ worked in) in gold = 5;
Chariot(s) worked in gold, with pole(s) (made of/ worked in) in *ʿgt*-material = 5"

This is also basically the case for the entry discussed here.

4.8.2. However, two types of vessels are mentioned in our passage, which results in an ambiguity: to which vessels do the handles belong? Is it all

[42] See TLA DZA 22.818.030; DZA 22.817.930; DZA 22.818.010.

[43] But see BARTA (1963, 79, 94–96) who interprets it as "metal".

[44] In this respect it is worth mentioning that Allam (ALLAM 1973, 185) interpreted it as a sort of cake. See also HELCK 1961–1969, IV, 675.

[45] See e.g., *ḏr.t m dšr* "hand(le)(s) made of *dšr*-wood" in relation to musical instruments in O. DeM 00950 r3, r5.

of them? Is it just the *šȝ-wȝ-b-tʸ*-like vessel(s)? Is it only the *ḥnw*-vessel(s)? Or is it some of each? It is very hard to say. According to the classifiers, *šȝ-wȝ-b-tʸ*-like vessels were probably jugs with one handle, while the classifiers of the word *ḥnw* point to handleless vessels. This could be read to mean that the silver handle(s) explicitly mentioned in the text belong to the *šȝ-wȝ-b-tʸ*-like vessel(s). However, one may also suggest that the scribe felt compelled to emphasise the presence of handles because the vessels he was listing usually did not have them – in which case, the *ḥnw* vessels may be a better candidate. It is impossible to say which option is preferable, both because there is no parallel in the surviving sections of the Annals and because, simply, the Egyptian construction is inherently ambiguous. The interpretation of *ḥnᶜ* is also relevant (see below): if we take it as coordinating two distinct subentries, then *ḏrt m ḥḏ* could only refer to the *ḥnw* vessels. If we take it as coordinating the *šȝ-wȝ-b-tʸ*-like vessels and *ḥnw* vessels as part of a same single entry, then in principle the "handles" may belong to both. Different interpretations also emerge depending on how we understand *n bjȝ*: in particular, if we take it to mean "made of metal," the passage may be understood as implying that the *ḥnw* vessels were composite vessels, with the bodies made of some (probably non-precious) metal that was not silver, but with the handles made of silver – and it was these handles that were relevant to the Egyptians and induced the scribe to list them alongside the *šȝ-wȝ-b-tʸ*-like vessels under the header *ḥḏ* = "silver."

4.9. Urk IV 733:7  = *jr~n dbn 56 qdt 3*

4.9.1 The final line provides the total weight of the objects received from the land/country called *tj-nȝ-y*: 56 *deben* and 3 *kite*.

In the Annals, the *deben* and the *kite* are clearly used as measures of weight, not value. In the New Kingdom, 1 *deben* corresponded to roughly 91 g, while 1 *kite* = 1/10 *deben* = 9.1 grams (Janssen 1975, 101). Therefore, the combined weight is about 5.123 kg.

5. Syntax

5.1. Although short, the passage discussed here presents a rather interesting and somewhat problematic syntax. The entry is composed of 5 distinct elements: [*ḥḏ*] [*šȝ-wȝ-b-tʸ m bȝk n kft(j)w*] [*ḥnᶜ*] [*ḥnw n bjȝ*] [*ḏrt m ḥḏ*] [*4*] followed by a conclusive [*jr~n dbn 56 qt 3*]. The first and main issue lies with the element [*4*]: what exactly is it referring to?

5.2. The phrasing and layout employed by Redford in his translation are somewhat ambiguous, and it is unclear how he connected the various elements. His translation and layout are as follows:

"[Benevolence of the chief] of Tanaya:
Silver: a jug of Keftiu workmanship along with vessels of iron
. . . with silver handle(s) 4, making 56 dbn, 3 kdt"

He certainly read "a" (*šȝ-wȝ-b-tʸ*-like) jug, but it is unclear how he understood the initial "silver,"[46] what exactly has "silver handles,"[47] and what the "4" refers to in his understanding of the text (4 handle(s)? 4 vessels? Vessels, 4 of which with silver handle(s)?). Finally, the ". . ." are also puzzling because the original hieroglyphic text is not broken and nothing in it justifies them.

Other translations are clearer. In particular, Cline (1994, 114) following Strange (1980, 96), translated it as: "Tribute from the prince of Tanaya: a silver shawabti-vessel in Keftiuan workmanship together with four bowls of iron (copper?) with handles of silver" and Vercoutter (1956, 55) translated it as "[Tribut du Chef] de Tinȝy (une) cruche-shaouabty d'argent en travail du pays Keftiou, ainsi que quatre vases de cuivre à anses d'argent. En tout (lit. cela fait) 56 deben 3 kite (soit environ 5 kg. 120 gr.)."

From the phrasing, it is clear that Vercoutter, Strange and Cline all analysed the text as:

([*ḥḏ*] [*šȝ-wȝ-b-tʸ m bȝk n kft(j)w*])
+
[*ḥnᶜ*]
+
([*ḥnw n bjȝ*] [*ḏrt m ḥḏ*]) = [*4*]
+
([*jr~n dbn 56 qt 3*])

Thus, understanding it as composed of two distinct subentries, namely one (or more) silver *šȝ-wȝ-*

[46] Is it referring only to the "jug," or to both the "jug" and the "vessels of iron"?

[47] Only the "vessels," or both the "jug" and the "vessels"?

b-tʸ-like vessel(s) on the one hand, and 4 *ḥnw* vessels with silver handle(s) on the other.

5.3. Assuming that the element [4] only refers to ([*ḥnw n bjꜣ*] [*ḏrt m ḥḏ*]) is certainly a possibility with a good parallel, e.g., in Urk. IV 705:13-4. This, however, is not the only option: an alternative would be to take it as referring to *all* the previous elements, thus analysing the passage as ([*ḥḏ*] [*šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ m bꜣk n kft(j)w*] [*ḫnᶜ*] [*ḥnw n bjꜣ*] [*ḏrt m ḥḏ*]) = [4]. A parallel for the use of *ḫnᶜ* to coordinate elements within a same (sub)entry of the Annals can be seen e.g., in Urk. IV 705:2-3:[48]  = *ḥḏ ḥnw n ḫꜣst ṯn ḫnᶜ sšw dbn 153* = "silver: vessels of this foreign land/country together with disk(s) = 153 deben".

5.4. Obviously, this general ambiguity can be combined in several ways with the other ambiguities highlighted above: lands or countries? One or more *šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ*-like vessel(s)? *ḥnw* -vessel(s) "for the *bjꜣ*-substance" or "made of metal"? And which ones are the vessels with "handle(s) made of silver"?

6. Conclusions – Translating the whole passage

Although the entry's overall meaning is clear and straightforward, all of these possible different interpretations can be combined in various ways, resulting in a set of permutations that differ in one or more details. Although they are often relatively secondary, these ambiguities and the possible variants deriving from them are an undeniable feature of this text, and as such they should be acknowledged and highlighted in the translation, both for the sake of accuracy, and to make other scholars (including those outside Egyptology, who may only have access to the text through translations) aware of its difficulties, as well as what is factually present and what is more a matter of interpretation. This obviously raises the question of how to translate such a text. Choosing a single translation from among all the possible combinations would be arbitrary, yet combining all possible variants into a single translation appears to be a difficult task. So, how should this passage be translated to reflect all these interpretative ambiguities accurately? A good compromise, in my opinion, would be to provide a restricted set of possible alternative translations that combine the elements that can be combined (e.g., by marking ambiguities about singular and plural with "–/s") and present as alternative versions those elements that cannot be easily combined in the same translation. Moreover, parentheses { [( )] } can be used to clarify the suggested underlying syntax, where it may be ambiguous.

Given this, I would propose the following set of possible translation(s) for the entire passage (note: reconstructed elements are marked with ⟪ ⟫), words required in English but absent in Egyptian are marked with ‹ ›):

⟪ *jnw*-delivery (?) of the ruler/s (?) ⟫ of the land/country called *tj-nꜣ-y*:

a. Silver: {*šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ*-like vessel/s in the workmanship of the land/country called *kft(j)w* together with [*ḥnw*/various vessels (made of metal)/(for/of the *bjꜣ*) ‹with› handle/s of silver]} = 4
   – Namely: there were only four silver vessels, counting both *šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ*-like vessel(s) and *ḥnw*/various vessels, the latter made of metal or for/of the *bjꜣ* and specifically with silver handles.
b. Silver: [*šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ*-like vessel/s in the workmanship of the land/country called *kft(j)w* together with *ḥnw*/various vessels (made of metal)/(for/of the *bjꜣ*)] ‹with› handle/s of silver = 4
   – Namely: there were only four silver vessels, counting both *šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ*-like vessel(s) and *ḥnw*/various vessels, the latter made of metal or for/of the *bjꜣ*. All four vessels had silver handles. For a parallel in which the same material is specified both for the items being listed, and for some of their parts, see Urk. IV 669:7 (discussed above, §4.5.6), which reads: *wrrt bꜣk.tj m nbw ḏbw m nbw* = "chariot(s) worked in gold, (with) ḏbw made of/worked in gold",
c. [Silver: *šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ*-like vessel/s in the workmanship of the land/country called *kft(j)w*] together with [*ḥnw*/various vessels (made of metal)/(for/of the *bjꜣ*) ‹with› handle/s of silver = 4]
   which makes 56 *deben* and 3 *kite*.
   – Namely: there were five or more vessels, i.e., one or more *šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ*-like vessel(s) made of silver, and four *ḥnw*/various vessels made of metal or for/of the *bjꜣ* with silver handles. The number 4 refers only to the *ḥnw*/various vessels, while the quantity of *šꜣ-wꜣ-b-tʸ*-like vessel(s) is not stated.

[48] See also Urk. IV 706:2-3.

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